

In electoral politics, the rush for a ticket—and the attendant revolt over its denial—is often an indicator of a political party's resurgent mood. The large number of applicants—508—for BJP ticket for the 65 assembly seats that go to the polls in Himachal Pradesh on December 19 has only reinforced the saffron party's comeback confidence.

But even as BJP is busy dousing discontent triggered by ticket distribution, its eleventh hour decision to project Prem Kumar Dhumal, a sitting Lok Sabha MP, as its chief ministerial candidate and cold shoulder the front-runner Shanta Kumar has suddenly warmed the cockles of the ruling Congress, which faces anti-incumbency in the hilly state.

By preferring Dhumal over Shanta, the party has taken a calculated gambit to settle the tricky leadership issue and shore up its electoral prospects beyond its traditional bastion of lower areas of the state. However, the move may backfire and sharpen the factional faultlines, considering the disquiet among Shanta's loyalists in the electorally-crucial Kangra district. By all accounts, the decision was guided more by internal politicking than merit. Though the party claims that Shanta has been kept on board and promised an important role in Central politics, the fact that he has opted not to contest from his home turf, Palampur is a pointer to the brewing trouble within the party. "Leaving Shanta out in the cold would prove costly for the party," says a senior BJP member.

But in the party high command's reckoning, Dhumal is the best bet to cash in on an across-the-board anti-incumbency sentiment even in upper Himachal regions comprising Shimla, Sirmour and Mandi districts, which were considered a Congress bastion and where BJP is trying to make a dent. Also, the party is keen to steer clear of its old trump card of alleging discrimination against the lower parts of the state by the Congress. "Projecting Shanta as the chief minis-



Photographs by ANU, DAKA

terial candidate would have polarised the electoral canvas and made it a lower Himachal versus the upper fight, much to the disadvantage of the party," says a state BJP leader. Also, the party was wary of offending the employees of the state Government and the apple growers—the two most influential lobbies, which had turned against Shanta during his stint as the chief minister in the early '90s.

However, keeping the issue of choosing a chief ministerial candidate in abeyance till the elections was only a ploy to outmanoeuvre Shanta by the pro-Dhumal lobby led by L.K. Advani. With A.B. Vajpayee out of the loop, Dhumal worked overtime behind the scene, pipping his one-time mentor to the post. "Projecting a clear choice for the post will benefit the party electorally," says Satya Pal

Jain, in-charge of the state party.

Dhumal's projection for the top job has lifted the spirits of the Congress which is now counting on BJP infighting to translate into electoral dividends in the Kangra region. Also, the Congress finds itself better placed to fight on the issue of corruption. It is vigorously sniping Dhumal for his "scandal-filled stint" as chief minister between 1998 and 2003.

As compared to the wrangling over the BJP ticket, the Congress ticketing has been a low key affair. While three senior leaders Sukh Ram, Sat Mahajan and Harsh Mahajan have opted not to contest, Chief Minister Virbhadra Singh has got away with a lion's share of tickets for his loyalists. His potential challenger Vidya Stokes has patched up with him, while other rivals including state Congress chief Viplove Thakur and Sukh Ram are content getting tickets for their kin.

In a state where political power has alternated between the Congress and BJP for the last four decades, it will be an uphill task for the ruling party to dodge the trend. Unless, of course, BJP squanders away the opportunity by fighting within rather than keeping its eyes on the target. **by Ramesh Vinayak**

UPHILL CHOICE

Infighting in BJP over the projection of Dhumal as the top candidate may just help Congress in the state



TESTING TIME: BJP's choice Dhumal (above); Chief Minister Virbhadra Singh